

The Paradigm Discourses

“The Quest”

The assurance of things hoped for; the conviction of things not seen.

It took a while, but eventually Paradigm noticed that it had gotten very quiet in the room. He looked up to see what the commotion, or rather lack of it, was about. He saw Faith standing in the foyer, fixed in a tableau with Understanding, poised almost nose to nose; neither was moving.

While it was well known that Paradigm and Dogma were often at odds, the tension between Faith and Understanding was legendary.

Faith turned and looked around the room making eye contact in turn with everyone present. Finally breaking the silence, she spoke to Understanding, “This is an impressive team you’ve assembled.”

Understanding nodded, maybe.

She wandered over to Theory & Experiment, who were standing side-by-side, “I see you two are still thick as thieves.” They glanced at each other, then back at Faith, but said nothing.

Paradigm noticed that Logic, Proof, Mathematics, and Reason had also clumped together. She sized them up as well.

Curiosity whispered in his ear, “I wonder what has brought her here tonight.” Paradigm glanced over his shoulder at her, only to notice that he and Dogma had also gravitated to each other. Well, there’s a first time for everything. The three of them silently watched.

Then Faith came over and stood in front of Dogma. Eventually she spoke, “I’m impressed, tickled even. Look how you’ve grown; in breadth, in length, in height, and depth. I couldn’t be more pleased.”

“Hello, mother.”

Curiosity, again in his ear, “I might have known.” Paradigm did a double take, he had been counting the dimensions in Faith’s comment to Dogma, four of them. What did Curiosity just say? Damn his inner dialog. Then he realized he was having an inner dialog about inner dialogs – *sheesh*, self-reference on steroids.

Faith turned to Paradigm. Her stare was intimidating. “So, you’re the new kid on the block.”

“Yes, ma’am.” Ma’am? Did he really say that?

“I hear you’ve accepted a quest.” Paradigm nodded.

Curiosity stepped forward, next to Paradigm, and stroke a posture of protectiveness, “Yes, he has, and it’s a dandy. Right or wrong, weak or strong,” she paused, “short or long; he has decided to see it through.”

Faith appraisingly, “You intend on having his back, don’t you?”

Defiantly, “Absolutely.”

Faith glancing around the assemblage, then directly at Paradigm, “You are in special company, unique and unparalleled company. I’ve watched this group grow over the years, each member

improving, each contributing. You are aware, I'm sure, that for an endeavor as challenging as the one you've accepted that you will need the help of everyone in this room?"

Paradigm, finally finding his tongue, "They are my friends, and my colleagues. Indeed, they may very well be my grounding. Being a part of this group, strike that, being a part of this *team* is an honor and a privilege."

"What makes you think you can succeed?" Was that a smile?

Gathering courage, which he was pleased to note was readily forthcoming, "Because I believe the realm makes sense, I'm certain sense can be made of what is. The past gives me confidence; old confusions have given way. We have been able to convert mystery into mastery. Some of the turns have been surprising, but the beauty and simplicity are astonishing. I have the conviction that things unseen can be revealed. Perhaps it is an assurance based on hope, but it's a rational hope. I'm not daunted by the uncertainty, but I am terrified of not seeking as deeply as possible. I want to know *why*."

Paradigm, actually leaning forward, looked at Faith intently, pondering, observing, then, "You get that; don't you. I see it in your eyes." She nodded, and this time it was definitely a smile. Paradigm continued, "You said I need everyone in this room. I think, perhaps, that that includes you too."

Faith, "Now you know why I showed up tonight."